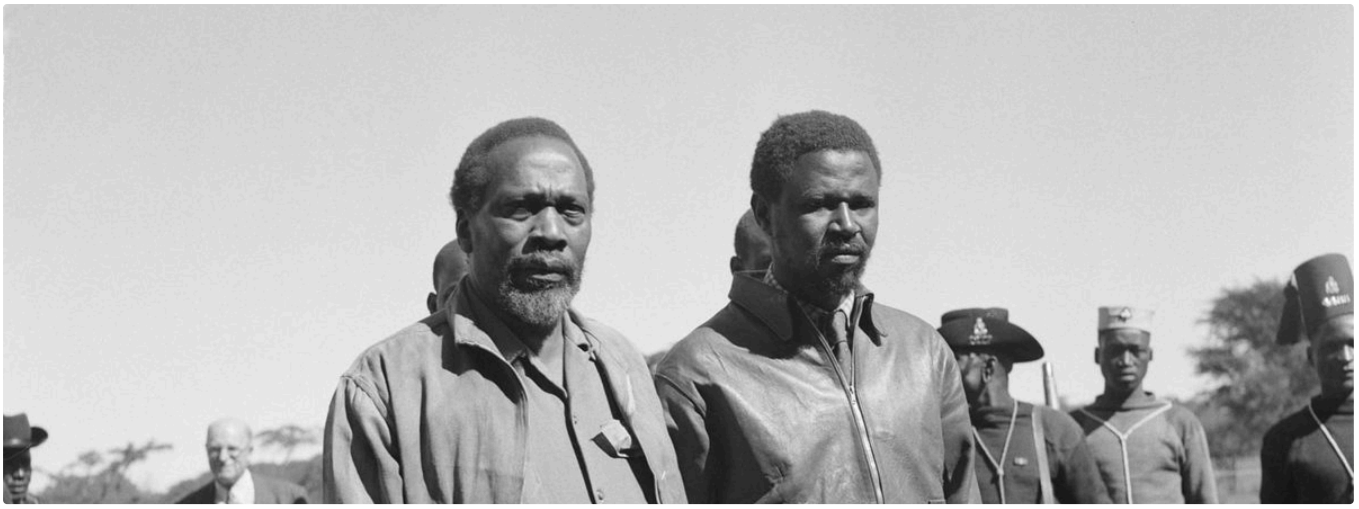
KENYA · 1952–1960 · AN ILLUSTRATED HISTORY · EDUCATIONAL EDITION

The Mau Mau Rebellion

Land, oaths and a state of emergency: how Kenya's forest fighters lost the war against Britain but won the argument that ended settler rule.



PHOTOGRAPH: Jomo Kenyatta (left, in the light jacket) under guard during the Kapenguria trial, December 1952. Britain jailed him as the alleged leader of Mau Mau. Eleven years later he became independent Kenya's first prime minister.

In the 1950s, thousands of Kenyans went into the forests of Mount Kenya and the Aberdare Range (Nyandarua) to fight the British colonial government, many armed only with homemade guns, spears and *pangas* (machetes). The British called the movement **Mau Mau**. Nobody agrees where the name came from, and the fighters seldom used it. They called themselves the **Kenya Land and Freedom Army**, and their goal was in that name: *ithaka na wiyathi*, "land and freedom" in Kikuyu.

Britain won the fighting: by 1956 the forest armies had been broken. But the rebellion, and the harsh methods used to crush it, destroyed the case for a Kenya ruled by white settlers. The State of Emergency ended in 1960, and Kenya became independent on 12 December 1963, led by the man Britain had imprisoned.

What you will learn. By the end of this booklet you should be able to:

- explain why land was the main cause of the rebellion;
- describe how peaceful protest gave way to armed resistance;
- outline the main events of the Emergency, 1952–1960;
- explain why Mau Mau was also a civil war among Africans;
- describe how Britain defeated it, including detention and villagisation;
- explain how a military defeat helped lead to independence;
- discuss how the conflict is remembered and debated today.

About the pictures: every picture is labelled PHOTOGRAPH or ILLUSTRATION. Photographs are real pictures from the period, or of places and memorials today. Where no usable photograph exists, an original painting was made for this document and is always labelled as an illustration. **How to use this booklet:** each chapter ends with questions to check your understanding. The last two pages give the numbers, key people, a glossary, a timeline and essay questions.

CHAPTER 1 · THE ROOTS

Land was at the heart of everything



ILLUSTRATION: Painting made for this document. A Kikuyu family works a small, crowded *shamba* (farm plot), while a fenced European estate spreads across the fertile land beyond, under Mount Kenya.

Britain declared the East Africa Protectorate in 1895 and built the Uganda Railway across it. To make the railway pay, it encouraged European farmers to settle. The **Crown Lands Ordinance of 1902** let the government grant land to settlers, and the **1915 Ordinance** declared all land, even land where Africans lived, to be Crown land. In 1920 the territory became the **Colony of Kenya**. The cool, well-watered highlands around Mount Kenya and the Rift Valley were reserved for Europeans and became known as the **"White Highlands"**. A few thousand settlers held this land, while more than a million Kikuyu, Embu and Meru people were confined to overcrowded **"native reserves"**. In 1932–34 the Carter Land Commission rejected most African land claims.

In the reserves, plots were divided among sons until many could no longer feed a family. Thousands became **squatters**, living and working on settler farms in return for a small plot, and they could be evicted at any time. Evictions in the 1940s, as at **Olenguruone**, drove families back to the reserves with nothing. African men also had to carry the **kipande**, an identity and labour pass worn in a metal case. Taxes payable in cash forced them into low-paid work on settler farms, and until the 1950s Africans were not allowed to grow coffee, the most valuable crop.

> **Key idea:** for the Kikuyu, land meant ancestry, a way of making a living and social status all at once. That is why a movement about land could win so much loyalty and demand so much sacrifice.

CHECK 1. Name two laws that took land from Africans. 2. Why did the squatter system cause anger in the 1940s?

CHAPTER 2 · 1920–1945 NEW

Before Mau Mau: early African protest

In 1921 **Harry Thuku** formed the East African Association to oppose the kipande, high taxes and the loss of land. When he was arrested in March 1922, a crowd gathered outside the Nairobi police station. **Mary Muthoni Nyanjiru** urged the crowd forward, and police and settlers opened fire, killing at least 21 people, she among them. The **Kikuyu Central Association (KCA)**, founded in the mid-1920s, carried on the campaign. In 1929 it sent its secretary, **Jomo Kenyatta**, to London. He stayed in Europe for about 15 years and in 1938 published *Facing Mount Kenya*, a defence of Kikuyu culture.

In 1929–31, when missions tried to ban female circumcision, an important Kikuyu initiation rite, many Kikuyu set up their own **independent schools and churches**, including a teachers' college at **Githunguri**. In 1940 the KCA was banned. Tens of thousands of Kenyans served in the Second World War, in Ethiopia and Burma. These **ex-servicemen** came home with military skills and high hopes, but found no land and the same colour bar. Some, like Waruhiu Itote ("General China"), later became forest commanders.

> **Pattern to notice:** petitions, associations, delegations and schools were all tried first. Each time, the return of land was refused, and a younger generation concluded that only force would work.

CHECK 1. What happened in Nairobi in March 1922? 2. How did the Second World War change African soldiers' attitudes?

CHAPTER 3 · 1944–1952 · POLITICS CLOSES, THE OATH OPENS

A movement takes an oath



ILLUSTRATION: Painting made for this document. A night oathing ceremony in central Kenya, early 1950s. Oathing was secret, so no genuine photograph of a ceremony exists.

The **Kenya African Union (KAU)**, founded in 1944 (first called the Kenya African Study Union), campaigned lawfully for land, wages and representation. Kenyatta returned in 1946 and became its president in 1947. Petitions and meetings changed almost nothing, because settlers dominated the **Legislative Council (LegCo)**, the colony's law-making body. Radicals, many of them trade unionists, ex-servicemen and evicted squatters, lost patience. After union leaders **Fred Kubai** and **Makhan Singh** were arrested in 1950, Nairobi held a general strike. A secret committee in Nairobi then directed an **oathing** campaign, and in August 1950 the government banned "Mau Mau".

The oath, based on Kikuyu tradition, bound people to unity, secrecy and the recovery of the land. A stronger *batuni* (platoon) oath bound fighters. Some took it willingly, and others were forced to. Oathing spread fast through the **passive wing**: farmers, traders and clerks who fed, hid and funded the fighters. **Women** were central, carrying food, messages and ammunition past checkpoints. Many Christians refused the oath, and some were killed for it. On **7 October 1952**, Senior Chief **Waruhiu**, a leading supporter of the government, was shot dead near Nairobi. The government decided to strike first.

CHECK 1. Why did radicals lose faith in KAU? 2. What was the "passive wing", and what did women do in it?

CHAPTER 4 · OCTOBER 1952

Emergency declared, leaders on trial



PHOTOGRAPH: Suspects rounded up in a mass *screening* sit under armed guard. Screening meant lining up and questioning whole communities, and it became the everyday face of the war for ordinary Kikuyu.

On **20 October 1952** Governor **Sir Evelyn Baring** declared a **State of Emergency**, which gave the government special powers such as arrest without trial. In **Operation Jock Scott**, police arrested Kenyatta and more than 150 others that night. The Emergency lasted until January 1960. Today 20 October is **Mashujaa (Heroes') Day** in Kenya.

The **Kapenguria Six** (Kenyatta, Bildad Kaggia, Fred Kubai, Kung'u Karumba, Paul Ngei and Achieng' Oneko) were tried in a remote town, far from crowds and journalists. They were defended by an international legal team led by D. N. Pritt. The main prosecution witness later swore that he had been bribed. In April 1953 all six were sentenced to seven years' hard labour. Oneko was cleared on appeal but kept in detention. KAU was banned in June 1953. With the moderate leaders gone, the forest fighters, who answered to no politician, became the main voice of the land demand.

> **1,090 people** were hanged for Emergency offences, the most in any British colonial emergency. The death penalty covered giving oaths, carrying ammunition and even "consorting with" fighters.

CHECK 1. Why do historians call the Kapenguria trial unfair? 2. How did removing the moderate leaders change the movement?

CHAPTER 5 · 1953–1956 · THE FOREST ARMIES

The forest war



ILLUSTRATION: Painting made for this document. Women couriers bring food into a hidden camp in the bamboo forest of the Aberdares. The forest armies depended on these supply lines from the villages.

The fighters organised as an army with ranks and councils. In the **Aberdares**, **Dedan Kimathi**, a former teacher and clerk, led alongside his rival **Stanley Mathenge**, whose fate is still unknown. On **Mount Kenya**, the leading

commander was **Waruhiu Itote, "General China"**. In 1953 the leaders formed a Kenya Defence Council headed by Kimathi. Some women fought too: **Muthoni wa Kirima** became a field marshal and stayed in the forest until 1963. Weapons were scarce, many of them homemade or captured, and all food and recruits came from the reserves.

The government side grew stronger under **General Sir George Erskine** (from June 1953). It had about 10,000 British troops, the **King's African Rifles**, more than 20,000 police and a similar number of Kikuyu Home Guard. Forests became "prohibited areas" where anyone could be shot, and the RAF bombed them. General China was captured in January 1954. Large sweeps such as Operations Hammer and First Flute (1955), amnesties, and **pseudo-gangs** of "turned" fighters led by British officers wore the fighters down. Kimathi was captured on **21 October 1956**, hanged at Kamiti Prison on **18 February 1957**, and buried in an unmarked grave.

CHECK 1. Which forest did Kimathi lead, and which did General China? 2. Give three reasons the fighters were defeated.

CHAPTER 6 · THE OTHER WAR

A war among the Kikuyu



PHOTOGRAPH: Armed men rest in the bush during the Emergency. Much of the government's fighting was done by African soldiers of the King's African Rifles and by the Kikuyu Home Guard.

Mau Mau was also a **civil war**. Most civilians it killed were Africans: chiefs, Home Guards, Christians who refused the oath and suspected informers. Only **32 European settlers** were killed, though murders such as that of the Ruck family in January 1953 shocked the world. The **loyalists** sided with the government for many reasons: faith, office, land, fear or anger at Mau Mau violence. The Kikuyu Home Guard defended villages and ran screening, and some of its members committed serious abuses too.

On the night of **26 March 1953**, at **Lari**, fighters attacked the homes of loyalist chief Luka Wakahangara and his supporters, killing about 74 to 97 people, many of them women and children. That same night another group raided Naivasha police station. Government and Home Guard **reprisals** after Lari may have killed even more. Britain used Lari to paint the whole movement as savage, while the reprisals drove more people to the forest.

> **Two truths at once:** Mau Mau was a genuine struggle for land and freedom, and it also committed atrocities against its own people. That is why its memory in Kenya has always been argued over.

CHECK 1. Who were the main victims of Mau Mau violence? 2. How did different sides use the Lari massacre?

CHAPTER 7 · HOW BRITAIN WON

Villages, camps and the Pipeline



PHOTOGRAPH: Detainees behind barbed wire. Tens of thousands of Kikuyu were held without trial in a system the government called the Pipeline.

On **24 April 1954**, **Operation Anvil** sealed off Nairobi and screened its whole African population, and tens of thousands were sent to camps. Across central Kenya, more than a million people were forced into about **800 fortified villages** behind ditches and wire. This **villagisation** cut the fighters' supplies, but it brought hunger, disease and forced labour to many who had never taken an oath.

Detainees entered the **Pipeline**, a chain of camps including Manyani, Mackinnon Road, Mwea, Kamiti (for women) and Hola. Prisoners were graded "white", "grey" or "black", and were beaten and pressured to confess and renounce the oath before moving towards release. Officially about 80,000 were held at the peak, and far more passed through in total. In 2011 a lawsuit by four elderly survivors forced Britain to reveal thousands of secret colonial files kept at **Hanslope Park**. They confirmed systematic abuse. In **June 2013** Britain paid **£19.9 million** to **5,228** claimants, and the Foreign Secretary said it "sincerely regrets that these abuses took place". A memorial in Uhuru Park, Nairobi, followed in 2015.

CHECK 1. How did villagisation help Britain win, and at what cost? 2. Why did the Hanslope Park files matter?

CHAPTER 8 · 1954–1960 · REFORM FROM ABOVE NEW

Land reform and the first African elections

Britain also used reform. The **Swynnerton Plan** (1954) combined scattered strips into single farms (**land consolidation**), gave owners **title deeds** and allowed Africans to grow coffee and tea. Many farmers prospered. But consolidation happened while tens of thousands of men were detained. Loyalists sat on the land committees and often gained the best land, while detainees' families lost theirs, creating a new land divide *among* Africans. Politically, the 1954 Lyttelton Constitution brought in the first African minister. In **1957** Africans elected eight LegCo members for the first time, including **Tom Mboya**, **Oginga Odinga**, **Ronald Ngala** and **Daniel arap Moi**. They demanded more seats and Kenyatta's release. Meanwhile the Emergency cost Britain about £55 million, and Ghana's independence in 1957 showed where Africa was heading.

CHECK Who gained and who lost from the Swynnerton Plan?

CHAPTER 9 · 1959–1960

Hola breaks the story in Britain



PHOTOGRAPH: Kikuyu men under guard during a screening operation. By the late 1950s, pictures and reports like this were turning British opinion against the Emergency.

On **3 March 1959**, at **Hola** camp near the Tana River, guards beat about 85 detainees who refused forced labour. **Eleven men died.** Officials first blamed contaminated water, but the inquest found that the men had died from violence. No one was convicted. MPs such as **Barbara Castle** had warned of camp abuses for years. In July 1959 the Conservative **Enoch Powell** told the Commons:

> *"We cannot say, 'We will have African standards in Africa, Asian standards in Asia and perhaps British standards here at home.'"*

Change came quickly. **Iain Macleod** became Colonial Secretary in October 1959. The Emergency ended on **12 January 1960**, and the first **Lancaster House Conference** promised an African majority in LegCo. Prime Minister Macmillan spoke of a "wind of change" in Africa. Two parties formed: **KANU** (Mboya, Odinga), which demanded independence and Kenyatta's release, and **KADU** (Ngala), which spoke for smaller communities.

CHECK 1. Why did it matter that a Conservative MP condemned Hola? 2. How did KANU and KADU differ?

CHAPTER 10 · 1960–1964 · UHURU

The road to independence



ILLUSTRATION: Painting made for this document; an artist's impression of independence night, 12 December 1963, as Kenya's flag rises. Photographs of the midnight ceremony are dark and unclear.

KANU won the 1961 election but refused to govern while Kenyatta was held. He was freed in **August 1961**. At Lancaster House in 1962, KADU won a regional system called *majimbo*, and the **Million-Acre Scheme** began buying settler land for African families. The land was bought, not returned. KANU won the **May 1963** election. On **1 June 1963** (**Madaraka**) Kenya gained self-government, with Kenyatta as prime minister. At midnight on **12 December 1963**, at what is now **Uhuru Gardens** in Nairobi, the Union Jack came down and Kenya's flag rose.

Prince Philip represented the Queen. Kenyatta preached forgiveness under the slogan ***harambee*** ("let us pull together"). Kenya became a **republic** on 12 December 1964, with Kenyatta as president.

> **Assessing the outcome:** Mau Mau lost its war. But without the rebellion and the high cost of defeating it, it is hard to believe Britain would have left Kenya in 1963, or handed power to Kenyatta.

CHECK What is the difference between Madaraka Day and Independence Day?

CHAPTER 11 · MEMORY

Memory, apology and the land that stayed divided



PHOTOGRAPH: The statue of Dedan Kimathi on Kimathi Street, Nairobi, unveiled on 18 February 2007, fifty years after his execution.

Independent Kenya did not at first honour Mau Mau. Kenyatta wanted unity and calm, and he is often quoted as calling it "a disease which had been eradicated, and must never be remembered again". The ban on Mau Mau lasted until **2003**. Many veterans died poor while former settler land often passed to a new elite. The **2010 Constitution** created Mashujaa Day. Kimathi's widow, **Mukami Kimathi**, campaigned until her death in 2023 for his grave to be found. In 2018 a larger claim by about 40,000 Kenyans was dismissed in London because too much time had passed. On a state visit in 2023, **King Charles III** called the "abhorrent and unjustifiable acts of violence" against Kenyans "a source of the greatest sorrow and the deepest regret". That was not a full apology. Novels such as Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o's *A Grain of Wheat* keep the story alive in schools.

> **Conclusion:** historians argue about the numbers, and Kenyans about who the rebellion belonged to. What is not disputed is that after Mau Mau, settler rule had no future.

REFERENCE

The numbers, the debates and the people

GROUP (APPROXIMATE FIGURES)	FIGURE	NOTES
Mau Mau fighters and suspects killed	about 11,000 (official)	Historian David Anderson estimates over 20,000.
African civilians killed by Mau Mau	about 1,800	Mostly loyalists, chiefs, Christians.
Security forces killed	about 170–200	Including 63 Europeans.
European / Asian civilians killed	32 / 26	
People hanged	1,090	Most in any British colonial emergency.
Detained without trial	about 80,000 at peak	Total who passed through was much higher.
Moved into guarded villages	over 1 million	About 800 villages, 1954–55.

What historians still debate

What was Mau Mau? A nationalist movement for all Kenya, or mainly a Kikuyu, Embu and Meru struggle over land that was also a civil war? Most historians now say it was both. **How many died?** Caroline Elkins (*Britain's Gulag*, 2005) argued that the camps were far larger and deadlier than admitted. Her highest estimates are disputed, but the 2011 files confirmed that the abuse was systematic. **Who won?** Britain won militarily. Politically, the rebellion made settler rule impossible, yet loyalists and educated politicians often gained more from independence than the fighters did. **The name?** It has never been explained for certain.

> **Study skill:** for any source, ask who made it, when and why. Colonial reports, settler memoirs, fighters' memoirs and court evidence all have different purposes and blind spots.

Key people

Jomo Kenyatta	KAU president; jailed 1953–61; first prime minister (1963) and president (1964–78).
Dedan Kimathi	Aberdare forest leader; captured 1956, hanged 1957.
Waruhiu Itote ("General China")	Ex-soldier; Mount Kenya commander; captured 1954.
Muthoni wa Kirima	Woman fighter who reached the rank of field marshal.
Harry Thuku	Early protest leader; his arrest led to the 1922 shooting.
Sir Evelyn Baring	Governor 1952–59; declared the Emergency.
Gen. Sir George Erskine	British commander, 1953–55.
Barbara Castle, Enoch Powell	British MPs from opposing parties who condemned the abuses.
Iain Macleod	Colonial Secretary from 1959; ended the Emergency.
Mboya, Odinga, Ngala	African leaders elected in 1957 who led the push for independence.

Glossary

Askari: African soldier or policeman in colonial service.
Harambee: "let us pull together"; Kenyatta's call for unity.
Kipande: compulsory pass for African men.
LegCo: Legislative Council, the colony's law-making body.
Loyalist: African who supported the government.
Madaraka: self-rule (1 June 1963).
Mashujaa: heroes; Mashujaa Day is 20 October.
Passive wing: civilians who supplied the fighters.
Pipeline: the chain of detention camps.
Pseudo-gang: "turned" ex-fighters used to hunt Mau Mau.
Screening: mass questioning of suspects.
Squatter: African labourer living on a settler farm.
Uhuru: freedom or independence (Kiswahili).
Villagisation: forced moves into guarded villages.

REFERENCE

Key dates

1895	East Africa Protectorate declared.
1902, 1915	Crown Lands Ordinances take African land.
1920	Kenya becomes a colony; kipande enforced.
Mar 1922	Thuku arrested; Nairobi shooting.
1929	Kenyatta to London; independent schools.
1940	KCA banned.
1944	KAU founded; Kenyatta president 1947.
1950	Nairobi general strike; Mau Mau banned.
7 Oct 1952	Senior Chief Waruhiu killed.
20 Oct 1952	Emergency declared; Kenyatta arrested.
26 Mar 1953	Lari massacre; Naivasha raid.
Apr 1953	Kapenguria Six convicted.
Jan 1954	General China captured.
Apr 1954	Operation Anvil; Swynnerton Plan.
21 Oct 1956	Kimathi captured.
18 Feb 1957	Kimathi hanged.
Mar 1957	First African LegCo elections.
3 Mar 1959	Hola: 11 detainees killed.
12 Jan 1960	Emergency ends.
1960	KANU and KADU formed.
Aug 1961	Kenyatta released.
1 Jun 1963	Madaraka (self-government).
12 Dec 1963	Independence (Uhuru).
12 Dec 1964	Kenya becomes a republic.
2003	Ban on Mau Mau lifted.
2007	Kimathi statue unveiled.
2013	Britain settles veterans' case.
2023	King Charles III expresses regret.

Review and essay questions

Short answer

1. What did *ithaka na wiyathi* mean?
2. Who were the Kapenguria Six?
3. What was Operation Anvil?
4. What happened at Hola in 1959?
5. What did Britain agree to in 2013?

Explain and analyse

6. "Land was the cause of everything." How far do you agree?
7. Why can Mau Mau be called both an anti-colonial war and a civil war?
8. "Mau Mau lost the war but won the peace." Assess this view.
9. Why has the memory of Mau Mau been contested in Kenya?

Source skill: why might a colonial report and a former detainee's memoir describe the same camp differently, and how would a historian use both?

Further reading

David Anderson, *Histories of the Hanged* (2005); Caroline Elkins, *Britain's Gulag* (2005); Daniel Branch, *Defeating Mau Mau, Creating Kenya* (2009); Tabitha Kanogo, *Squatters and the Roots of Mau Mau* (1987). Memoirs: Waruhiu Itote, *"Mau Mau" General* (1967); J. M. Kariuki, *"Mau Mau" Detainee* (1963). Literature: Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o, *Weep Not, Child* (1964), *A Grain of Wheat* (1967); Ngũgĩ and Micere Mugo, *The Trial of Dedan Kimathi* (1976).

Sources: the Hola inquest findings; the Kapenguria trial record; the Hanslope Park "migrated archives" and the 2013 UK settlement; King Charles III's Nairobi speech (October 2023); and the histories above. Elkins's highest estimates remain debated.